

Mental Healthcare

Can We Create a New Kerala Model?

Panel Discussion

Moderator :Ms. Devika S. Kumar, Panelist :Ms .Ashna C, Panelist :Ms. Henna Ayub,

Panelist :Mr. Nithin Lalachan

Quick Brief Summary

This session calls for changing the social stigma surrounding mental health and making services more accessible through primary health centers. While leveraging the potential of technology, the speakers assess that professional regulations and the active involvement of students are essential to building a new Kerala model.

Detailed Summary

Introduction

The session 'Mental Healthcare - Can We Create a New Kerala Model?', held as part of the Kerala Psychology Conclave, began as a discussion between mental health experts Ms. Devika S. Kumar, Mr. Fawaz M., Ms. Henna Ayub, and Mr. Nithin Lalachan. The primary objective of this session was to discuss general awareness regarding mental health, the limitations of current systems, and the need for community-based models.

Main Theme: A New Kerala Model for Mental Health

The focal point of this discussion was how to make mental health services more popular and accessible within Kerala's social context. The speakers analyzed how to build a new model at the community level by addressing existing stigma, the lack of service availability, and the absence of professional regulations.

Key Areas Explored

Mental Health and Social Awareness

The speakers emphasized the need to view mental health through a proactive approach. Instead of seeking treatment only after problems worsen, seeking counseling when minor difficulties arise

can pave the way for a major change. However, due to the stigma that still exists in society, many hesitate to seek help. The mindset that views visiting a counseling center as 'madness' needs to change.

Accessibility and DMHP

Although government systems like the District Mental Health Program (DMHP) exist in Kerala, there is low awareness among the public regarding their operations. By ensuring the services of psychologists at PHCs (Primary Health Centers), mental healthcare can be made more accessible to the common person. The speakers pointed out that the lack of availability of services is a greater barrier than stigma.

Technology and Online Therapy

The growth of online counseling after COVID-19 brought about a major change. However, the use of AI technologies like ChatGPT also raises concerns in the mental health sector. Precise legislation is required regarding data privacy, therapist burnout, and confidentiality. While leveraging technology, it is necessary to ensure that the essence of therapy is not lost.

KEY INSIGHTS: Main Recommendations

1. **Networking:** Strong networking between psychology students and professionals is essential for the growth of this field.
2. **Regulation:** Strict laws and regulations are needed to prevent interventions by unqualified individuals.
3. **Education and Exposure:** Beyond academic studies, students should focus on internships and research papers to gain practical knowledge.
4. **Community Model:** By ensuring the service of a psychologist in every PHC, mental healthcare can be popularized just like general health services.

Conclusion

The speakers reminded the audience that mental health is not something that can be changed by government policies alone, and that every individual must take responsibility. Psychology students should be more actively involved in this field and take the initiative to break the stigma. The session concluded with a call for everyone to work together to build a new Kerala model.

Highlights

Accessibility of Mental Health Services and Stigma

The main barrier to seeking mental health services is not just stigma (social prejudices), but also the lack of accessibility to services. Priority should be given to making psychologist services available in rural areas and educating society to view mental health as a normal health issue.

The Importance of a Proactive Approach

Seeking counseling before problems become severe is more effective. Whether it is relationship issues or other mental difficulties, intervening early helps avoid major crises.

Technology and Ethics

Although online counseling services increase accessibility, extreme care is needed regarding data privacy, therapist burnout, and confidentiality. When using technology, one must ensure that the fundamental values of therapy are not lost.

Networking and Professional Growth

Psychology students should connect with each other during their studies and gain practical experience through internships and research papers. This will help them become excellent professionals in the future.